# A Vishnu Sculpture from Kelzar, District Wardha, Maharashtra

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***Abstract***: *Vishnu the most revered deity of Hindu pantheon, having cult followers from all over the world, in the form of Vaishnavites, Bhagavata, Cult of Krishna, Bhakti Tradition, Cult of Rama, Cult of Vitthal (Varkari Pantheon), The Alvars, Visishthadvaita, Advaita. The religious system where Vishnu and his forms are the objects of worship and otherwise called Vaishnavism, Vishnu is a god of the Hindu triad and Vaishnavism is one of the major Religious sects of India even today.*

***Keywords***: Vishnu Sculpture, Iconography, Rupamandana**,** Vaishnavism, Kelzar, Wardha, Attributes

## Introduction

Vishnu the Supreme God of Vaishnavism, one of the three principal denominations of Hinduism and one of the three supreme deities (*Trimurti*) of Hinduism, is also known as Lord Narayana and Lord Hari. One of the five primary forms of God in the Smarta tradition conceived as "the Preserver or the Protector" within the Trimurti, the Hindu Trinity of the divinity. In almost all Hindu denominations, Vishnu is, either, worshipped directly or in the form of his ten avatars the most famous being, Rama and Krishna. Traditional explanation of the name *Vishnu* involves the root *viś* meaning "to settle" (cognate with Latin *vicus,* English *-wich* "village," Slavic: vas *-ves*), or also (in the RigVeda) "to enter into, to pervade," glossing the name as "the All-Pervading One". Yaska, an early commentator on the Vedas, in his Nirukta, (etymological interpretation), defines Vishnu as '*viṣṇur viṣvater vā vyaśnoter vā*', 'one who enters everywhere'. He also writes, '*atha yad viṣito bhavati tad viṣnurbhavati'*, 'that which is free from fetters and bondages is Vishnu'. Adi Shankara in his commentary on the *Sahasranama* states derivation from *viś,* with a meaning 'presence everywhere' ('As he pervades everything, *vevesti*, he is called *Vishnu*'). Adi Shankara states (regarding Visnupurana, 3.1.45): "The Power of the Supreme Being has entered within the universe. The root *viś* means enter into" Swami Chinmayananda, in his translation of Vishnu Sahasranama further elaborates on that verse: "The root *viś* means to enter. He pervades the entire world of things and beings and the Upanishad emphatically insists

in its mantra 'whatever that is there is the world of change". Hence, it means that He is not, limited by space, time or substance. Chinmayananda states that, that which pervades everything is Vishnu.

## Vishnu in Hindu Triad

In the Vedas Vishnu distinguishes himself only for the 'three steps' with which he measures out the extent of the earth and the heavens. The significance of this act is, amplified to include other functions in the epics, where Vishnu is, equated with Prajapati, the creator and supreme god. As Prajapati, he encompasses Brahma, Vishnu himself as preserver, and Shiva as destroyer. Narayana, 'moving in the waters'; in this character he is represented in a human form, sleeping on the coiled serpent Shesha, or Ananta, and floating on the waters. Brahma is, said to have arisen from a lotus growing from his navel as he slept thus. After each, destruction of the universe, Vishnu resumes his posture.

## Iconography

When Vishnu is not reclining on the coils of the serpent Shesha, with Lakshmi seated at his feet, he is, shown as a handsome young man with blue skin, dressed in royal robes. He has four hands; one holds a conch shell or Sankha, the second hand holds a discus, an attribute of Krishna's, given to him by Agni as a reward for defeating Indra; the third hand holds a club or mace called Kaunodaki, presented to Krishna on the same occasion; the fourth hand holds a lotus, or Padma. He also has a bow called Sarnga, and a sword called Nandaka. He is usually, either seated on lotus with Lakshmi beside him, or riding on his vehicle, Garuda, who is half-man and half-bird. Vishnu's heaven is, called Vaikuntha, sometimes said to be on Mount Meru, though this is more often, given as the location of Indra's heaven. According to various Puranas, Vishnu is the ultimate omnipresent reality and is shapeless.

The following iconography governs his representations: (1) He has four arms and is male: The four arms indicate his all-powerful and all-pervasive nature. His physical existence is, represented by the two arms in the front, while the two arms at the back represent his presence in the spiritual world. The Upanishad *Gopal Uttartapani* describes the four arms. (2) The *Shreevatsa* mark is on his chest, symbolizing his consort Lakshmi. (3) He wears the auspicious "Kaustubha" jewel around his neck and a garland of vaijayanti flowers (Vanamala). Lakshmi dwells in this jewel, on Vishnu's chest. (4) A crown adorns his head: The crown symbolizes his supreme authority. This crown sometimes includes a peacock feather, borrowing from his Krishnavatar. (5) He wears earrings: The earrings represent inherent opposites in creation — knowledge and ignorance; happiness and unhappiness; pleasure and pain. (6) He rests on Ananta, the immortal and infinite snake.

Vishnu has been depicted holding four attributes; (1) A conch shell or *Shankha*, named *Panchajanya* is held by the upper left hand. It represents Vishnu's power to create and maintain the universe. Panchajanya represents the five elements or *Panchabhoota* –

water, fire, air, earth and sky or space. It also represents the five airs or Pranas that are within the body and mind. The conch symbolizes that Vishnu is the primeval Divine sound of creation and continuity. It is also represented as Om.

**Table 1: Arrangement of Sankha, Chakra, Gada and Padma in the four hands of each of the 24 images of Vishnu according to Rupamudra**

| Sl. No. | Name of Image | Back Right Hand | Back Left Hand | Front Left Hand | Front Right Hand |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Kesava | Shankha | Chakra | Gada | Padma |
| 2 | Narayana | Padma | Gada | Chakra | Shankha |
| 3 | Madhava | Chakra | Shankha | Padma | Gada |
| 4 | Govinda | Gada | Padma | Shankha | Chakra |
| 5 | Vishnu | Padma | Shankha | Chakra | Gada |
| 6 | Madhusudhana | Shankha | Padma | Gada | Chakra |
| 7 | Trivikrama | Gada | Chakra | Shankha | Padma |
| 8 | Vamana | Chakra | Gada | Padma | Shankha |
| 9 | Sridhara | Chakra | Gada | Shankha | Padma |
| 10 | Hrishikesa | Chakra | Padma | Shankha | Gada |
| 11 | Padmanabha | Padma | Chakra | Gada | Shankha |
| 12 | Damodara | Shankha | Gada | Chakra | Padma |
| 13 | Samkarshana | Shankha | Padma | Chakra | Gada |
| 14 | Vasudeva | Shankha | Chakra | Padma | Gada |
| 15 | Pradyumna | Shankha | Gada | Padma | Chakra |
| 16 | Aniruddha | Gada | Shankha | Padma | Chakra |
| 17 | Purushottama | Padma | Shankha | Gada | Chakra |
| 18 | Adhokshaja | Gada | Shankha | Chakra | Padma |
| 19 | Narasimha | Padma | Gada | Shankha | Chakra |
| 20 | Achyuta | Padma | Chakra | Shankha | Gada |
| 21 | Janardana | Chakra | Shankha | Gada | Padma |
| 22 | Upendra | Gada | Chakra | Padma | Shankha |
| 23 | Hari | Chakra | Padma | Gada | Shankha |
| 24 | Sri-Krishna | Gada | Padma | Chakra | Shankha |

In the Bhagavad Gita, Krishna avatara states that of sound vibrations, 'He is Om'. (2) The Chakra, a sharp, spinning, discus-like weapon, named "Sudarshana" is, held by the upper right hand. It symbolizes the purified spiritualized mind. The name *Sudarshana* is derived from two words–*Su*, which means *good*, *superior*, and *Darshana*, which means *vision* or *sight*; together. The Chakra represents destruction of ego in the awakening and realization of the soul's original nature and god, burning away spiritual ignorance and illusion, and developing higher spiritual vision and insight to realize god. (3) A mace or *Gada*, named 'Kaumodaki' is, held by the lower right hand, which symbolizes that Vishnu's divine power is the source of all spiritual, mental and physical strength. It also signifies Vishnu's power to destroy materialistic or demonic tendencies (Anarthas)

that prevent people from reaching god. Vishnu's mace is the power of the Divine within us to spiritually purify and uplift us from our materialistic bonds. (4) A lotus flower or Padma is, held by the lower left hand. It represents spiritual liberation, Divine perfection, purity and the unfolding of Spiritual consciousness within the individual. The lotus opening its petals in the light of the Sun is indicative of the expansion and awakening of our long dormant, original spiritual consciousness in the light of god. The lotus symbolizes that god is the power and source from which the universe and the individual soul emerges. It also represents Divine Truth or Satya, the originator of the rules of conduct or Dharma, and Divine Vedic knowledge or Jnana. The lotus also symbolizes that Vishnu is the embodiment of spiritual perfection and purity and that He is the wellspring of these qualities and that the individual soul must seek to awaken these intrinsic Divine qualities from Vishnu by surrendering to and linking with him. To this may be, added conventionally, Vishnu's bow (Shaarnga/Kodand) and his sword Nandaka.

## Twenty-Four Images of Vishnu/Chaturvimshati Murtayah

Rupamandana gives 24 names of Vishnu (Table 1) and the corresponding arrangement of four articles in the four hands in each case to notice the difference between the various images at a glance.

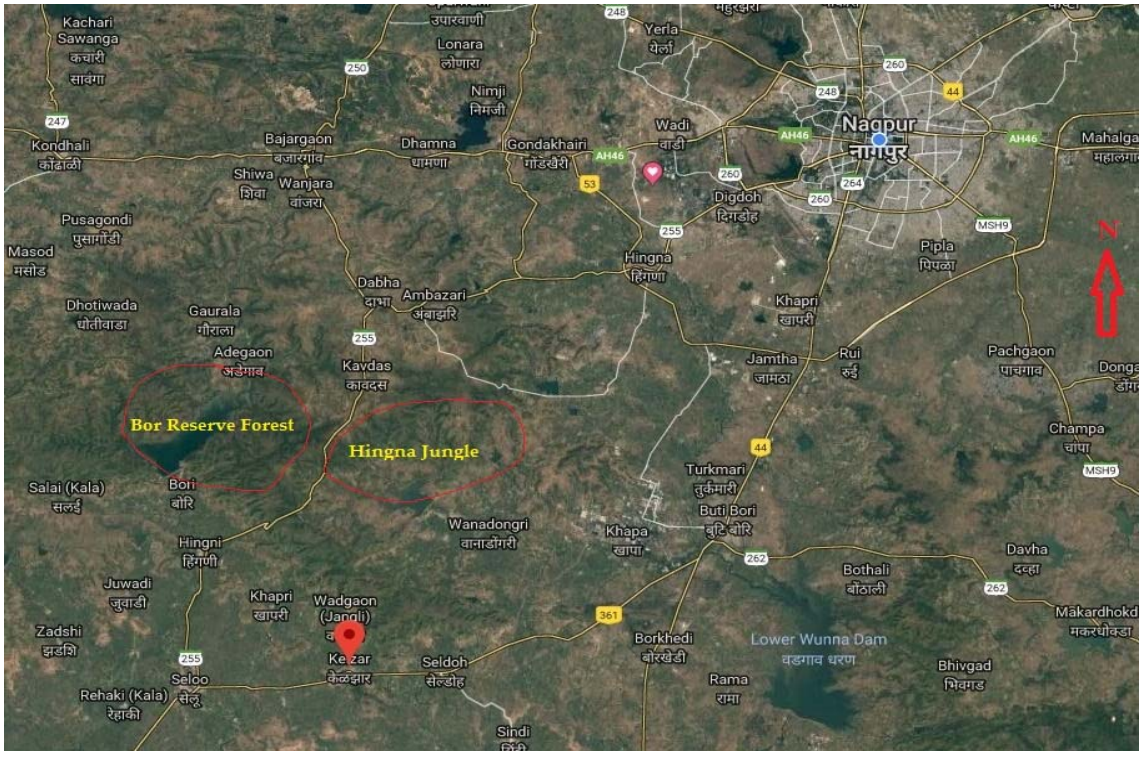



**Figure 1: Location of Kelzar, Nagpur**

## Kelzar – the Site

Kelzar (20.8470° N; 78.8013° E) is, situated in Tehsil: Seloo District: Wardha on Nagpur – Aurangabad road 46kms south-west of Nagpur towards Wardha (Figure 1). Kelzar is

bordered Bor Tiger reserve towards its south-west side along with Bor Water reservoir and Dam and bordered by Hingna jungles on the northern side with ample naturally formed lakes and reservoirs, which keeps the area irrigated throughout whole year.

The name Kelzar means the village of plantain trees, it contains a medieval ruined fort on the hilltop mound and inside the fort is the temple of Siddhivinayak Ganapati. Kelzar is, believed to occupy the site of the old city of *Chakranagar* described in the *Mahabharata*. North-western side of the mound is flanked by a small water reservoir (Figure 2).

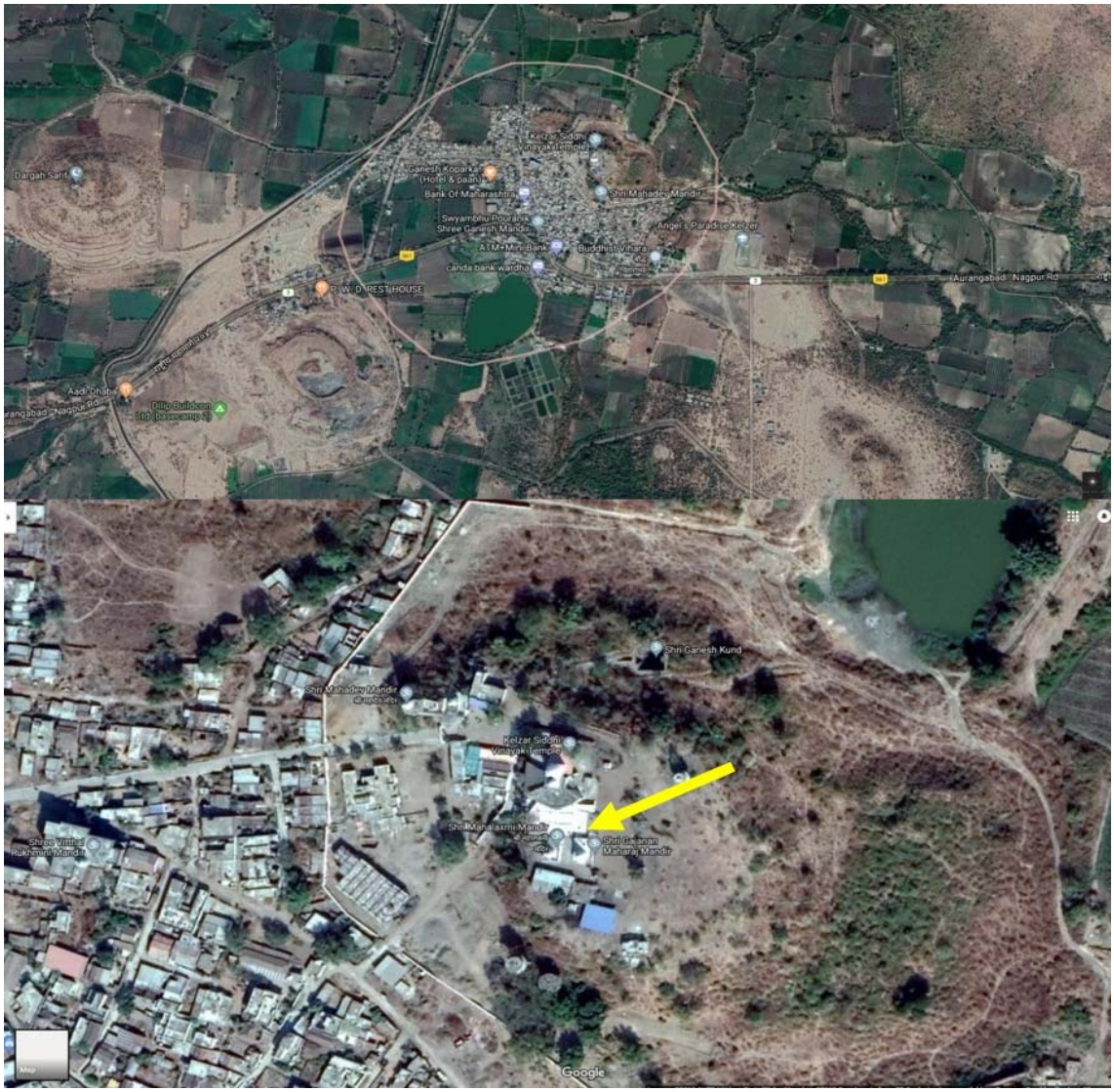



**Figure 2: Aerial view of Kelzar Siddhivinayak Temple and Sculpture Find Spot**

## Discussion

A Beautifully carved best-preserved and intact Vishnu Sculpture on Deccan Trap/Basalt/Black Stone (Figure 3) having a height of 15" and breadth of 6" was, found during the clearing of surrounding area of the famous Siddhivinayak temple at Kelzar,

as per authorities' discussion with author during his exploratory visit. To prevent further damage and pilferage temple authorities fixed the sculpture into concrete wall on outside entrance of temple.

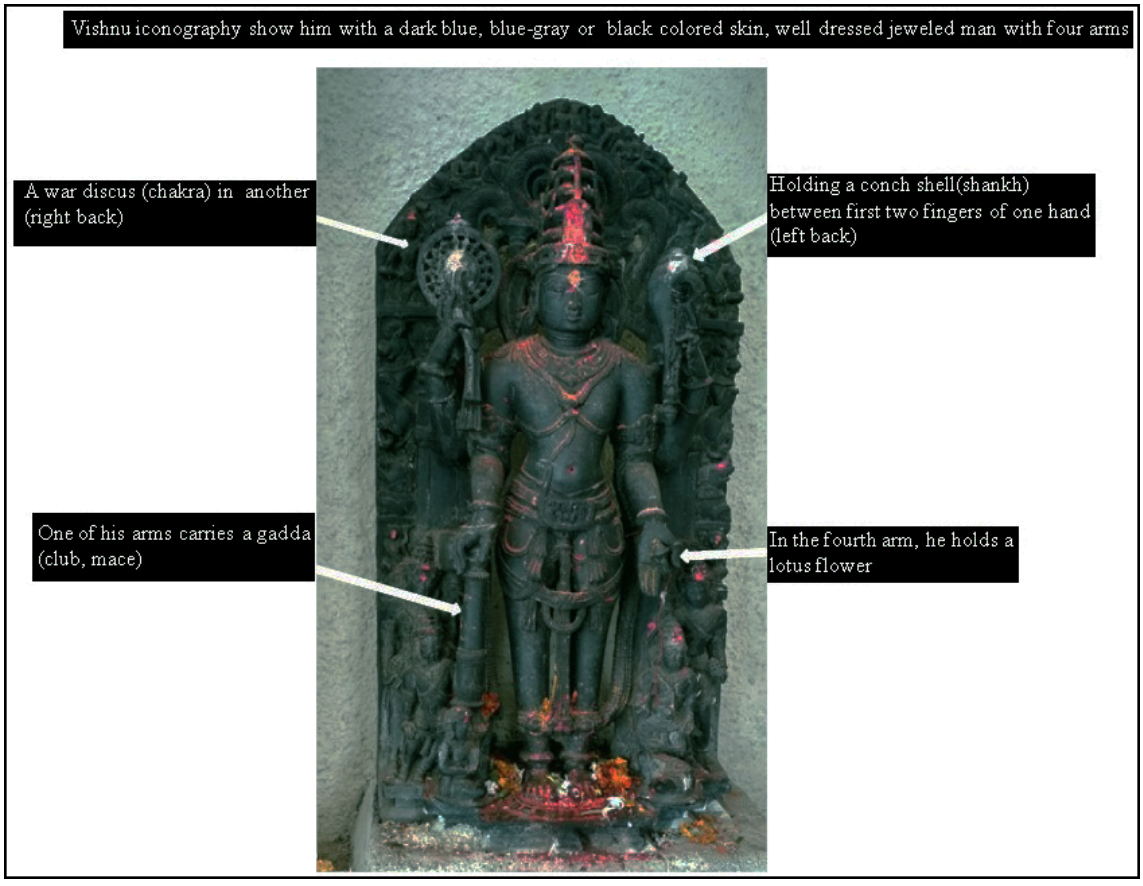



**Figure 3: Iconographic Features of Vishnu Image from Kelzar**

The Vishnu sculpture is, intricately carved revealing all the features such as long earrings, large decorative armlets in four arms, anklets, and on his chest the distinctive curl and the jewel Kaustubha. Top of the image above the high royal crown we can see detailed *Parikar* carved depiction of Dasavtaras from left to right, and to the side of right and left hand, we can see *Ganas* carrying elephant on their head, which in turn is carrying lion like mythical creature on both the sides identified as *Gajavyal*. Below the Ganas, *Jay* and *Vijay* the accomplice of lord along with devotees worshipping in various forms is seen.

## Conclusion

Vaishnavism had roots in Deccan right from early period along with Shaivism and continued until 14th Century AD. By observation and detailed study of the sculpture and its iconography, we place the Vishnu Sculpture found at Kelzar between ninth and 11th Century AD i.e. during the reign of later Chalukyas or Rashtrakutas or at the most, to the Yadavas of Devagiri who came late into Vidarbha and established themselves. By studying the arrangement of Sankha, Chakra, Gada and Padma in the four hands of

the image, it can be, notified as 'Madhava' according to Rupamandana. Some temples of Ramtek (Ramagiri) are from Yadava times, similar sculpture was, found at Parshivni and is, worshipped.

## Acknowledgement

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